No one has advanced any convincing answers to these questions; they are among the pressing research problems driving current cosmological research and they serve to remind us of the many tangled knots we must still unravel before we can claim to have fully understood the birth of the universe. But despite the significant challenges that remain, inflation is far and away the front-running cosmological theory. To be sure, physicists' belief in inflation is grounded in the achievements we've so far discussed. But the confidence in inflationary cosmology has roots that run deeper still. As we'll see in the next chapter, a number of other considerations— coming from both observational and theoretical discoveries—have convinced many physicists who work in the field that the inflationary framework is our generation's most important and most lasting contribution to cosmological science.